instance of his ability to seize upon categories from the Western repertoire, and to translate them and bend them to his own purposes, so allowing him to live and recount his own, non-Western – and distinctively modern – Indian life.

The modernity of the life he created lay most fundamentally in the sense that it was a chosen life (even if often stumblingly so), and also one whose past meaning was revisable in the light of future choices. It was in no sense foreclosed or pre-destined as, traditionally, a Hindu might have conceived his or her life. Nor was it directed by spiritual masters or gurus. Gandhi speaks of his disappointments in his search for a guide, and dwells on the influence upon him of the Jain teacher, Raychandbhai, only to acknowledge that even in his late fifties, 'the throne remains vacant' in his spiritual heart. Equally, he did not see his life as simply formed – and deformed – by the pressures and seductions of the modern world. By conducting his life as an experiment, he saw himself as akin to a scientist controlling a laboratory session, who 'never claims any finality about his conclusions, but keeps an open mind regarding them'.

The sense of choice expresses itself across the defining areas of Gandhi's life: family, community, religion, God, the pursuit of truth. He refused to accept the conventional images or content ascribed to any of these, and strove instead to create his own sense of each. Thus, he transplanted his family into unfamiliar situations, became a teacher to his wife, and worried over their clothes, their food, and over how their children should be brought up (in these tasks, he turned often to one of his favourite